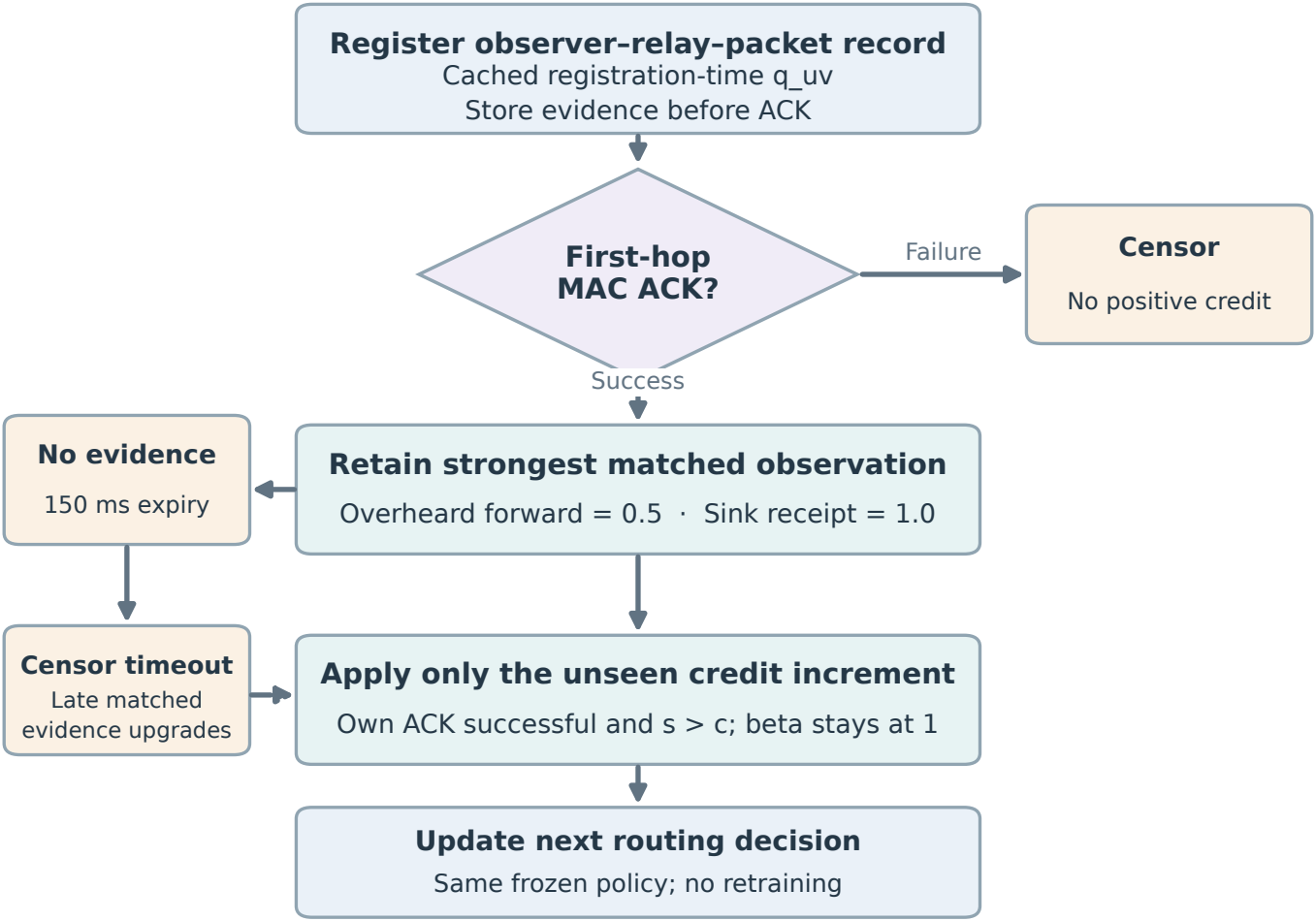ACK-gated evidence and credit lifecycle